

Chapter 3: Formalism

Quantum Mechanics

1 Commutators

2 Hermitian Operators

Definition 2.1 (Hermitian Conjugate). [def:hermitian-conjugate] The *Hermitian conjugate* of an operator $\hat{O}$ is denoted $\hat{O}^\dagger$ and is defined by the property

$$\forall f, g, \langle f | \hat{O} g \rangle = \langle \hat{O}^\dagger f | g \rangle$$

Remark 2.1 (Hermitian Conjugate as Matrix Transpose). [rem:hermitian-conjugate-as-matrix-transpose] If $\hat{O}$ is represented as a matrix, then the Hermitian conjugate is the complex conjugate transpose of that matrix. ie,

$$H^\dagger = (H^T)^*$$

Definition 2.2 (Hermitian Operator). [def:hermitian-operator] An operator $\hat{O}$ is *Hermitian* if it is equal to its Hermitian conjugate, i.e. $\hat{O}^\dagger = \hat{O}$.

3 Unitary Operators

Definition 3.1 (Unitary Operator). [def:unitary-operator] An operator $\hat{U}$ is *unitary* if it satisfies the property $\hat{U}^\dagger \hat{U} = \hat{U} \hat{U}^\dagger = \hat{I}$, where $\hat{I}$ is the identity operator.

4 Conjugation and Similarity Transforms

Definition 4.1 (Conjugation Action). [def:conjugation-action] The *conjugation action* of an operator $\hat{U}$ on another operator $\hat{A}$ is defined as

$$\hat{A} \longmapsto \hat{U}^\dagger \hat{A} \hat{U}$$

After applying the operator $\hat{U}$ to $|\psi\rangle$, the expected value of $\hat{A}$ becomes

$$\langle \hat{U} \psi | \hat{A} | \hat{U} \psi \rangle = \langle \psi | \hat{U}^\dagger \hat{A} \hat{U} | \psi \rangle.$$

So the conjugation action gives the transformed operator $\hat{U}^\dagger \hat{A} \hat{U}$ whose expected value on the original state $|\psi\rangle$ matches $\hat{A}$'s expected value on the transformed state $\hat{U} |\psi\rangle$.

5 Functions of Operators

Definition 5.1 (Holomorphic Functional Calculus). [def:operator-function] For every function f analytic in a neighborhood of some center $c \in \mathbb{C}$, with Taylor expansion

$$f(z) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{f^{(n)}(c)}{n!} (z - c)^n,$$

and every operator $\hat{A}$, define

$$f(\hat{A}) := \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{f^{(n)}(c)}{n!} (\hat{A} - c \hat{I})^n$$

(subject to convergence; $\hat{I}$ is the identity operator). This blanket recipe defines a canonical map $f \mapsto f(\hat{A})$ from analytic scalar functions to operators, known as the *holomorphic functional calculus*.

Example 5.1 (Operator Exponential). [ex:operator-exponential] Take $f(z) = e^z$ with center $c = 0$. Since $(e^z)^{(n)} = e^z$ and $e^0 = 1$, we have $f^{(n)}(0) = 1$ for all n , so the scalar Taylor series reads

$$e^z = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{z^n}{n!}.$$

Feed this into the operator recipe. With $c = 0$, the shift $\hat{A} - c\hat{I} = \hat{A}$, giving

$$e^{\hat{A}} := \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{f^{(n)}(0)}{n!} \hat{A}^n = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{\hat{A}^n}{n!}.$$

Remark 5.1 ($f(\hat{A})$ Is a Constructed Operator). [rem:operator-function-meaning] $f(\hat{A})$ is not literal function application: $\hat{A}$ is an operator, not a scalar. The symbol names a *new operator* built from f 's Taylor coefficients (scalars) and $\hat{A}$'s powers, using only operations that operators support (powers, scalar multiplication, addition).

Remark 5.2 ($f(\hat{A})$ Is a First-Class Operator). [rem:operator-function-first-class]

- Once built, $f(\hat{A})$ is an ordinary operator: add, compose, conjugate, or nest as usual. Commutes with $\hat{A}$ and any $g(\hat{A})$; may not commute with operators outside $\{\hat{A}\}$'s commutant.
- The choice of center c is a computational convenience only — $f(\hat{A})$ is intrinsic, and different centers give the same operator where their series converge.

Theorem 5.1 (Action on Eigenvectors). [thm:operator-function-eigenvector] If $\hat{A}|\lambda\rangle = \lambda|\lambda\rangle$, then $f(\hat{A})|\lambda\rangle = f(\lambda)|\lambda\rangle$.

Proof. Since $\hat{A}^n|\lambda\rangle = \lambda^n|\lambda\rangle$, we have $(\hat{A} - c\hat{I})^n|\lambda\rangle = (\lambda - c)^n|\lambda\rangle$, so

$$f(\hat{A})|\lambda\rangle = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{f^{(n)}(c)}{n!} (\lambda - c)^n |\lambda\rangle = f(\lambda)|\lambda\rangle.$$

□